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A Stylometric Analysis of Chinese Literary Inheritance and Divergence: Evidence from Shen Congwen and Wang Zengqi

Abstract

Shen Congwen (SCW) and Wang Zengqi (WZQ), as prominent figures in modern Chinese literature, are widely known for their well-established master-disciple relationship. Although this literary connection implies a transmission of aesthetic and linguistic values, their works exhibit marked stylistic differences. This study examines the stylometric inheritance and divergence of SCW and WZQ. We constructed a dedicated corpus of their writings, with a total size of several million words, and analyzed 18 linguistic features, including lexical richness, descriptivity, activity, nominality, keywords, word length distribution, and part-of-speech distribution. In addition, the study employed principal component analysis to uncover potential clustering and distinguishing patterns among different stylistic features. The findings show that both authors inherited the thematic orientation of the Beijing School and shared a preference for defamiliarized expression. SCW prioritizes dynamic narrative rhythms with high lexical richness. His style is defined by a somber, lyrical intensity and emotional gravity, maintaining a highly consistent and unified aesthetic. WZQ favors static scene depiction, seamlessly blending vernacular idioms with poetic allusions. His style is versatile and hybridized (classical-modern), underpinned by a consistently warm and serene narrative tone. By integrating the evolution of Modern Chinese, socio-historical contexts, and personal creative philosophies, this study further explores the underlying causes of these stylistic divergences, thereby revealing the inherent complexity of literary evolution.

Keywords: stylometric; stylistic variation; literary inheritance; Shen Congwen; Wang Zengqi

Introduction

Literature is fundamentally an art of language, with its aesthetic value realized through linguistic expression. As a major research domain within linguistics, linguistic style has become an important analytical entry point for literary studies. Traditionally, research on linguistic style has relied predominantly on qualitative approaches, employing close reading and case studies to explore the distinctiveness and literary characteristics of an author's style (Leech, 2014). However, such qualitative approaches are often influenced by subjective interpretation, and the resulting findings

tend to lack objective scientific validation, making it difficult to generate systematic and replicable results. Although the definition of style remains a topic of ongoing debate (Fang and Liu, 2023), the rise of digital humanities has introduced new methodological possibilities through quantitative stylistics. In the context of quantitative stylistics, style is defined as “a property of texts constituted by an ensemble of formal features which can be observed quantitatively or qualitatively” (Herrmann et al., 2015). Stylometry offers a data-driven, objective, and replicable approach to the study of linguistic style in literary texts, enabling researchers to revisit longstanding literary questions with enhanced analytical rigor (Holmes, 1998 ; Grieve, 2023)

As a literary school with a unique creative ethos and aesthetic paradigm, the Beijing School emerged with its stylistic proto-form in the mid-1920s and attained its apogee during the mid-1930s. Writers of the Beijing School generally maintained a politically detached stance, integrating Chinese cultural traditions with Western modernist elements. Grounded in the core literary principle of aestheticism, they emphasized the aesthetic function of literature and resisted its instrumentalization, advocating for the depiction of pure beauty and cultivating a stylistic approach characterized as “writing deep feelings with a light pen.” Beijing School authors placed great importance on aesthetic autonomy, the conscious exploration of language and form, and the nuanced portrayal of everyday life and human experience (Ding, 2007; Liu, 2021).

Shen Congwen (1902 – 1988) serves as a representative author of the Beijing School and has long been identified as a prototypical figure within “native soil” fiction in modern Chinese literature. Although SCW never played an explicit role in the “Root-Seeking” (Xungen) movement, the “imaginary nostalgia” embedded in his native soil writings established the fundamental genealogy for the rural imagination of younger generations, profoundly influencing the stylistic output of numerous authors (Wang, 1993). Furthermore, Kinkley (2006) defines him as a pioneer of China’s academic modernism, affirming his pivotal position within the diachronic evolution of modern Chinese literature.

Wang Zengqi (1920 – 1997) was a primary disciple of SCW and is recognized as the final

successor to the Beijing School literary lineage represented by SCW (Zhai, 2004). WZQ is widely recognized as a highly innovative and avant-garde figure in modern and contemporary native-soil literature. While his work inherits the nostalgia and regionality characteristic of the genre, he engages in bold formal and linguistic experimentation. Moving away from a preoccupation with the representation of material hardship, WZQ emphasizes a reconstruction of the native soil through the lenses of textuality and memory. His creative work not only revitalized native-soil literature but also exerted a profound influence on the Roots-Seeking movement. Consequently, he is hailed as a representative figure of neo-nostalgia (Wang, 1993; Fitzgerald, 2008).

It is evident that SCW and WZQ are two monumental figures within the landscapes of modern Chinese literature and the Beijing School. Within the genealogy of Chinese literary tradition, writers who share a master-disciple relationship or belong to the same literary movement often exhibit analogous stylistic traits and linguistic habits (Li and Li 2023); alternatively, they may have certain kinds of artistic brilliance in common (Kinkley, 2006). First, both authors inherited the aestheticism of the Beijing School in their creative endeavors, prioritizing the nuanced depiction of humanity and human relations (Liu, 2021). Second, due to their frequent engagement with rural themes, SCW and WZQ are characterized as native-soil writers in the history of the Chinese novel; furthermore, both have exerted a profound influence on the development of Roots-Seeking literature (Wang, 1993; Fitzgerald, 2008). WZQ formally studied under SCW, and his literary development was profoundly shaped by this master-disciple relationship. He repeatedly acknowledged influence of SCW on his creative style. The shared literary lineage and master-disciple relationship between SCW and WZQ provide a solid basis for comparative analysis. Their writing styles are often described as “seemingly plain but emotionally resonant” (Tai, 2003).

However, this master-disciple lineage belies profound historical imprints and individual idiosyncrasies. Taking the socio-historical context as an example, SCW’s creative output was deeply rooted in the turbulent transformations of modern China; his writing was perpetually characterized by a profound preoccupation with the disintegration of traditional ethics under the

onslaught of modern civilization. By comparison, WZQ's literary resurgence took place during a historical period defined by the gradual restoration of social order and a moderating cultural ethos. These multifaceted discrepancies have produced a complex pattern of both convergence and divergence in their language use, narrative perspectives, and approaches to character construction (Xia, 1990). Moreover, the creative peaks of the two authors correspond respectively to the first and the third periods in the development of Modern Chinese. Individual development is embedded in broader social change, authors' literary practices respond to their socio-cultural contexts, thereby giving rise to linguistic styles marked by the characteristics of their respective historical periods (Zhu, 2006). Consequently, quantitative analysis of literary texts not only reveals the authors' individual stylistic features, but also provides linguistic evidence for examining the evolution of Modern Chinese across different periods. According to James (2012), literary innovation and inheritance can be understood as a dynamic interplay rather than a static process of replication. This interplay is not limited to English literary traditions, and the present study brings a case from modern Chinese literature into this broader theoretical discussion.

The stylistic convergences and divergences observed within the well-defined master-disciple relationship between SCW and WZQ prompt important questions regarding the linguistic realization of literary inheritance. However, such stylistic dynamics have rarely been examined through systematic, data-driven methodologies. This study takes the master-disciple relationship as its contextual foundation and applies quantitative stylistic methods to investigate potential stylistic similarities and differences in the literary texts of SCW and WZQ. Our contribution lies in providing new empirical evidence that literary inheritance is not a static process of imitation, but rather a dynamic interplay between inheritance and innovation. This finding not only offers literary scholars a fresh interpretive perspective for close reading of the works of SCW and WZQ but also extends the methodological scope of stylometric research by demonstrating how quantitative approaches can capture both continuity and divergence in literary style, thereby inspiring new interdisciplinary pathways for literary analysis.

Literature review

Research in quantitative stylistics has yielded substantial results, with its core objective being the analysis of textual stylistic features through quantitative indicators. These features span multiple linguistic levels, including phonological, lexical, syntactic, and even discourse-level dimensions. Of these linguistic dimensions, lexical features have received the most extensive scholarly attention and constitute the most fully developed area within the field. The lexical feature system typically includes a range of indicators, such as keywords (Hui, 2023), lexical richness (Kubát and Milička, 2013), activity, descriptivity, nominality (Zörnig et al., 2015), distribution of word length (Liu and Xiao, 2020), part-of-speech composition (Hou and Jiang, 2016), content words (Huang and Liu, 2009), and function words (Binogo and Smith, 1999). Each type of lexical indicator captures a distinct dimension of linguistic style, and together they constitute a multidimensional framework for the stylistic analysis of literary works.

There are multiple research perspectives on quantitative stylistics within literary studies. One approach involves the static description of an individual author's style, aiming to uncover the distinctive stylistic features embedded in their works (Yildirim and Can, 2024). Another adopts a diachronic perspective, focusing on how an author's stylistic patterns evolve over time (McIntyre and Walker, 2022). In addition to author-centered research, substantial progress has also been made in examining the stylistic characteristics of specific literary schools (Brooke et al., 2017), conducting comparative analyses across different literary traditions (Chen and Kubát, 2022), and exploring stylistic variation among multiple authors (Yildirim and Can, 2024).

The application of quantitative stylistics in literary studies is well established, providing a robust framework for the textual analysis of diverse genres. For instance, Hao et al. (2025) compared modern Chinese poetry and prose regarding linguistic naturalness and part-of-speech distribution, while elucidating the underlying drivers of these stylistic features. Andreev (2016) examined the proportions of verbs, adjectives, and nouns in Pushkin's Long Poems to investigate the interplay between static and dynamic thematic expressions in Russian verse. Similarly, Chen

and Kubát (2022) employed a suite of linguistic features to distinguish the stylistic and thematic nuances between rural and urban fiction in contemporary Chinese literature.

In recent years, research in quantitative stylistics has undergone notable methodological expansion, with scholars gradually shifting from traditional statistical approaches to more advanced multivariate analysis techniques (MVA), including principal component analysis (PCA), hierarchical clustering, and random forest methods (Hoover, 2003).

Scholarly attention to SCW and WZQ has remained consistent, particularly in the domain of qualitative literary analysis, where numerous studies have explored the stylistic convergences and divergences between the two authors (Xia, 1990). Regarding the affective tone of their texts, SCW's works are imbued with a sense of somber and profound pathos, whereas WZQ's oeuvre exudes a mellow optimism characterized by equanimity and warmth (Lei 2007). In terms of literary genre, SCW explored and implemented the form of the poetic novel; he noted that he composed with a lyrical tone and synthesized his materials to investigate whether they could yield an effect akin to prose poetry. In contrast, WZQ crosses genre boundaries between essay, fiction, poetry, music, and painting (FitzGerald, 2008), manifesting a more open and transdisciplinary approach to stylistic experimentation. In terms of compositional style, SCW's writing represents a hybridity of Europeanized and Japanese elements, combined with Classical Chinese and the regional characteristics of Hunan (Gunn, 1991). In contrast, WZQ mixes classical Chinese (wenyan) with contemporary vernacular and regional languages, manifesting a linguistic style that blends the classical and the modern (FitzGerald, 2008; Lin, 2015). Specifically, SCW's works are characterized by a Euro-Japanese style and the extensive use of pronouns and adjectival modifiers. WZQ, however, sought to break free from the influence of Europeanized (Ouhua) or translated style (fanyiti) writing, striving instead to construct and pursue a more authentic Chinese style (FitzGerald, 2008; Gao, 2019). However, their approaches to defamiliarization at the linguistic level diverge in notable ways. Yan and Su (2011) observe that in *Bian Cheng*, SCW often replaces disyllabic words or compound syntactic constructions with monosyllabic expressions. This

strategy not only enhances linguistic conciseness and clarity but also aligns with the restrained and implicit aesthetic characteristic of classical Chinese prose, thereby achieving a defamiliarizing stylistic effect. By contrast, WZQ excels in achieving defamiliarization through the inventive blending of colloquial language, folk expressions, and classical literary forms, thereby constructing a hybrid linguistic style that disrupts readers' conventional expectations and enhances the aesthetic estrangement effect (Liu, 2015).

From a quantitative perspective, Hou and Huang (2020) analyze the linguistic styles of SCW and WZQ, though their study primarily focuses on phonological features. Their research highlights the difficulty of identifying WZQ's texts when using tone motifs and word-length motifs as stylistic representations. However, it does not offer a deeper exploration of the underlying reasons for this phenomenon. Furthermore, as their study encompasses multiple authors and centers on automated style recognition, it lacks a focused quantitative analysis of SCW and WZQ within the framework of their pedagogical lineage. Consequently, while their findings provide certain interpretive value, they remain insufficient for a comprehensive empirical understanding of the stylistic inheritance and divergence between the two authors. In summary, existing scholarship on the linguistic styles of SCW and WZQ remains largely grounded in subjective impressions or introspective interpretations. While such approaches reflect a high degree of literary sensitivity, they often lack empirical validation, which limits the generalizability of their conclusions. Moreover, most existing studies are based on a narrow selection of excerpts rather than a representative corpus, thus lacking the support of large-scale data. To address these limitations, this study adopts a quantitative stylistic approach, integrating multidimensional lexical indicators to investigate the stylistic affinities and variances between SCW and WZQ. The specific research questions are:

RQ1: Which stylometric indicators most effectively differentiate the literary works of SCW and WZQ?

RQ2: Can Principal Component Analysis (PCA) reveal distinct clustering patterns in the

overall stylistic features of the two authors' writings?

RQ3: Within the framework of literary lineage, in what specific linguistic features are inheritance and innovation manifested between SCW and WZQ?

RQ4: What factors contribute to the stylistic differences between the authors?

Material

The selection of corpus materials is a critical methodological consideration in stylistic analysis, as it directly influences the representativeness and validity of the findings. This study concentrates on fiction and prose, two genres widely recognized as core literary registers. According to SCW's autobiography (Shen, 1985), his creative period can be categorized into three stages, which cover the periods 1924 to 1929, 1930 to 1935, and 1936 to 1949. Representative works such as *Bian Cheng*, *Xiao Xiao* and *Xiang Xing San Ji* were all written during the 1930 – 1935 period. Therefore, this study selects all of SCW's novels and prose from this period to construct a literary corpus of his works. WZQ's literary output is divided into three distinct phases, with the 1980s representing the peak of his creative career. Works such as *Shou Jie* and *Da Nao Ji Shi* were written during this time. Accordingly, this study selects all of WZQ's novels and prose from the 1980s to build a corresponding literary corpus.

Furthermore, attention should be paid to the temporal differences corresponding to the peak creative periods of the two authors. Societal transformation serves as a central driver of linguistic evolution, profoundly shaping the linguistic forms characteristic of a given historical period (Cui et al., 2022). During SCW's peak creative period (1930 – 1935), Chinese society was situated at an extraordinarily complex and turbulent historical turning point. From a socio-historical perspective, the intervention of external forces disrupted the previously closed social framework, with the Japanese invasion profoundly undermining China's national sovereignty and social order. The resulting national crisis reached unprecedented levels, making the imperative of national salvation a central concern in both social and intellectual spheres. Simultaneously, this period also provided Chinese people with greater exposure to the wider world, as Western concepts such as

science and democracy entered China. Translation of Western texts became a crucial channel through which intellectuals engaged with and assimilated Western thought (Cui et al., 2022). In terms of cultural and linguistic movements, although more than a decade had passed since the May Fourth Movement, the vernacular literature movement it championed continued to exert a profound influence on literary creation and the development of modern Chinese. Amid the wave of “language reform” (yuyan gaige), the vernacular (baihua) was formally established as “the national language” (guoyu), marking a milestone transformation that not only decisively overturned the centuries-long hegemonic status of classical Chinese (wenyan) but also undermined its legitimacy, which had been historically grounded in traditional literary lineages (Peter and Chiang, 1979; Chen, 2015). In terms of language development, this period belongs to the early stage of modern Chinese. Literary language during this stage was highly complex, characterized by the coexistence of classical vocabulary and colloquial expressions, strong dialectal coloring, and significant influence from Indo-European languages, particularly English, as well as Japanese (Cui et al., 2022). By contrast, WZQ’s creative peak occurred primarily after 1980. During this period, with the advent of Reform and Opening-up, scholars began to reflect on the “linguistic turn” of the early twentieth century and sought to revive traditional Chinese culture (Chen, 2015). In terms of social context, while China in the 1980s was actively integrating into the global economic order, cultural and literary policies also showed clear signs of relaxation. Intellectuals represented by WZQ attempted to break away from the long-dominant literary paradigm characterized by strong political centralism and to revive traditional Chinese culture by searching for roots in language. They rejected the binary opposition that equated vernacular Chinese with progress and classical Chinese with backwardness, redefining modern Chinese as an organic whole that carries the essence of national culture and bridges past and present, encompassing the practicality of vernacular Chinese while also incorporating the cultural depth of classical Chinese and the diversity of dialects (FitzGerald, 2008; Chen, 2015). In terms of language development, this period corresponds to the third stage of modern Chinese. At the lexical level, this stage of modern Chinese

is characterized by the expansion of semantic categories, diversification of lexical sources, and an increased proportion of polysyllabic words (Liang, 2022). However, a systematic analysis of semantic categories lies beyond the scope of the present study and will be addressed in future research.

In summary, the corpus selection in this study is guided both by the representativeness of the authors' creative styles and by their positioning within the broader contexts of modern Chinese literary history and the historical development of modern Chinese. As two prominent figures in Chinese literary history who share a clear master–disciple relationship and belong to the same literary school, SCW and WZQ provide strong comparability for stylistic analysis. Moreover, the differences in historical context and stages of modern Chinese corresponding to their peak creative periods elevate individual stylistic variation to a macro level encompassing literary history and language evolution, thereby facilitating an examination of stylistic variation within a lineage and the intrinsic connections between literary language and sociohistorical change. Table 1 presents the basic information of the corpora.

The collected texts underwent cleaning, word segmentation, and part-of-speech tagging, manual proofreading. Given that elements such as the publication information, table of contents, and epigraphs differ significantly from the main text in terms of linguistic features and textual structure, they were excluded from the analysis. Word segmentation and part-of-speech tagging were conducted using the LTP 4.0 Base2 model developed by the Harbin Institute of Technology (Che et al., 2020).

Methods

The lexical metrics examined in this study include lexical richness, descriptivity, activity, nominality, keywords, word length distribution, and part-of-speech distribution. To ensure the statistical validity of the difference analysis, normality tests were conducted for each variable prior to the correlation procedures. Specifically, the Kolmogorov-Smirnov (K-S) test and the Shapiro-Wilk test were employed. Variables were considered to follow a normal distribution if the p-values

in both tests exceeded 0.05, in which case independent samples t-tests were used for group comparisons. For variables that did not meet the assumption of normality, the Mann-Whitney U test was applied. In addition, this study employed PCA, a commonly used statistical method for dimensionality reduction, which transforms a set of potentially correlated variables into a set of linearly independent new variables through orthogonal transformation.

Results

Keywords. Keyword extraction can effectively identify the core semantic content of texts and reveal authors' thematic preferences and choices (Hu and He, 2022). Van Dijk (2005) points out that texts can generate meaning only when textual knowledge is connected to the world. This principle is grounded in the core semantic functions that content words fulfill within the linguistic system. Accordingly, this study focuses on nouns, verbs, and adjectives, three categories of content words that carry primary semantic functions. Nouns are typically entity-denoting words with concrete lexical meaning and often serve as keywords conveying textual themes (Pan, 2015), while verbs and adjectives reflect the actions and attributes of central entities (Popescu et al., 2009). Therefore, by selecting nouns, verbs, and adjectives as the objects of analysis, this study seeks to explore the thematic structure, interaction patterns, and emotional tone underlying literary works. This study employs the Term Frequency–Inverse Document Frequency (TF-IDF) algorithm (Sparck Jones, 1972), which assumes that a word's importance is directly proportional to its frequency within a document and inversely proportional to its frequency across the corpus. The statistical results are presented in Table 2.

Regarding nouns, the vast majority of keywords for both authors are character-related. This indicates that while both writers excel at characterization, their creative orientations exhibit distinct differences. As shown in Table 2, SCW frequently centers his narratives on young individuals, with particular emphasis on the life circumstances of rural youth with an educational background. In addition, the frequent occurrence of gender-specific terms such as 女人 (woman), 妇人 (married

woman), 女子(girl) suggests that female characters occupy a central position in SCW's literary works. He is known for creating a series of iconic female figures, including Cui Cui (from *Bian Cheng*), Xiao Xiao (from *Xiao Xiao*), and A Jin (from *Zhang Fu*). In contrast, WZQ's works exhibit a broader generational span, encompassing characters from adolescence, through middle age, to old age, thereby reflecting a more comprehensive engagement with the complexities of human life across different stages. Furthermore, terms such as 和尚 (monk), 同志 (comrade), 作家 (writer) underscore the diversity of professions among his characters, reflecting his broad interest in the lives of individuals across various social strata. Meanwhile, we observe that concrete locational nouns such as 联大(Southwest Associated University) and 昆明 appear with high frequency in WZQ's works, reflecting that his creation is deeply rooted in his authentic personal life trajectory. This persistence with specific locales aligns with Edward Casey's (1987) proposition that spaces serve as convenient points of attachment for memory. For WZQ who had been away from his hometown for over forty years and was acutely aware that most real-world relics had been destroyed, these concrete toponyms are more than mere geographical markers; they function as congealed scenes for memory content. By amassing locational nouns, he established solid habitats of memory within his texts, thereby achieving a creative reconstruction of his lost native land. In contrast, the frequency of concrete locational nouns in SCW's texts is significantly lower. Even his signature regional concept, 湘西(Western Hunan), ranks only 182nd in the keyword frequency statistics, suggesting that his rural writing focuses more on an idealized, imagistic spatial construction that transcends specific geographical coordinates. Second, in terms of verbs, both authors frequently employ cognitive and perceptual verbs such as 以为 (think), 看到 (see), and 觉得 (feel), suggesting a shared narrative strategy that advances the plot through the subjective experiences and internal perceptions of their characters.

The frequent use of psychological verbs such as 欢喜 (like) and 愿意 (willing) in the works of SCW is indicative of an emphasis on inner emotional portrayal, which enhances the lyrical tone of his narrative. However, the key verbs in the writings of WZQ are often related to

mundane bodily actions, particularly those with directional significance such as 起来 (rise up) and 出来 (come out). This suggests that he emphasizes the depiction of character actions in his writing, providing his works with a strong sense of everyday life.

Finally, the analysis of adjectival keywords enables an exploration of the affective orientation in the writings of both authors. Specifically, the frequent occurrence of adjectives such as 沉默 (silent) and 寂寞 (lonely) in SCW's texts reveals a predominant affective tone characterized by introspection and melancholy. This markedly contrasts with the predominantly positive and vibrant emotional coloring conveyed by the adjectival choices in WZQ's works. This interpretation is consistent with the findings reported by Lei (2007). By contrast, WZQ tends to favor adjectives such as 好吃 (delicious) and 好看 (beautiful), which are closely linked to quotidian experience and underscore a narrative orientation grounded in everyday life. Furthermore, the two authors exhibit distinct lexical preferences when describing youth and expressing the concept of affection.

Activity, Descriptivity, Nominality. Activity, Descriptivity, and Nominality are widely used indicators in the field of quantitative stylistics research (Zörnig, 2015). Chen and Kubát (2022) emphasize that texts can generally be divided into two categories: static texts (which focus on depicting objects such as landscapes, characters, and places) and more dynamic texts (which focus on the development of the storyline).

As shown in Fig 1, both authors exhibit a similar pattern characteristics across the three stylistic indicators, with the Activity value being the highest, the Nominality value in the middle, and the Descriptivity value the lowest. The consistency in the distribution of these indicators suggests a similarity in their writing styles. Specifically, both authors tend to use high-frequency verbs to create a dynamic narrative rhythm, select moderately conceptualized expressions, and the significantly low Descriptivity value reflects their tendency to use fewer modifying elements. However, despite these pattern similarities, the t-test and Mann-Whitney U test revealed significant differences between the two authors on the three indicators: Activity ($u = 10158.0, z = -3.800, p =$

0.00), Descriptivity ($u = 10158.0$, $z = -3.800$, $p = 0.00$), and Nominality ($t = 9.554$, $df = 416$, $p = 0.00$).

Specifically, the texts of SCW exhibit a higher level of Activity, indicating that SCW frequently uses verbs to create a dynamic narrative rhythm and emphasizes the progression of the storyline, while WZQ shows a higher level of Descriptivity, suggesting that he focuses more on the depiction of landscapes, characters, and places (Chen and Kubát, 2022). Figure. 3c shows that the difference in Nominality is more significant, with the average Nominality value in the WZQ corpus (0.529) being higher than that of the SCW corpus (0.482). To investigate the underlying causes of this difference, a more detailed textual analysis was carried out. The three articles with the highest Nominality values in the WZQ corpus are *Qingtang Guomian* (0.624), *Kunming de Hua* (0.62), and *Diling Renjie Hua Huai'an* (0.618). These works all involve the description of local cuisine, flowers, or regional characteristics, requiring the use of numerous nouns to depict specific objects and their features. For example, in *Kunming de Hua*, WZQ uses nouns such as “leaf,” “petal,” and “flowering period” to provide detailed descriptions of the types, appearance, color, shape, and growing environment of flowers like “camellia” and “orchid”. The frequent use of nouns contributes to the increase in the Nominality value in his texts. The study by Chen and Kubát (2022) indicates that the proportion of nouns is related to the thematic focus of a text. Many of WZQ’s novels and essays begin with explorations of language and naming conventions, and this creative preference also contributes to a higher frequency of noun usage (FitzGerald, 2008). It is worth noting that, as shown in Figures 1a and 1b, WZQ exhibits a greater number of outliers, indicating a higher degree of variation in Activity and Descriptivity in his works, which reflects the adaptability and flexibility of WZQ’s linguistic style. In contrast, SCW shows fewer outliers, highlighting the stability and consistency of his linguistic style.

Lexical richness. In quantitative stylistics, the validity of lexical richness as a stylistic marker has been extensively tested and validated, making it an indispensable analytical dimension (Kubát and

Milička, 2013). However, the majority of lexical richness indicators exhibit length-dependency, meaning that the measurement results are significantly affected by token count, leading to notable fluctuations. Accordingly, this study adopts the Moving-Average Type-Token Ratio (MATTR), a text-length-independent measure of lexical richness proposed by Covington and McFall (2010). We measured the text in segments by setting different window length parameters ($L = 50, 100, 150$) and calculated the arithmetic mean of three independent measurements to obtain the lexical richness (MATTR_mean).

Both SCW and WZQ exhibit a high level of lexical richness, with MATTR_mean values exceeding 0.7. This result suggests that both authors demonstrate a sophisticated command of language through their varied lexical choices. The lexical richness of SCW (0.752) is slightly higher than the value of WZQ (0.747). The Mann-Whitney U test reveals a significant difference in lexical richness between the two authors ($U = 11590.0$, $Z = -2.347$, $p = 0.019$). The higher lexical richness observed in texts by SCW indicates an ability to employ a more diverse vocabulary for describing objects, conveying emotions, and articulating perspectives. As shown in Fig. 2, the lexical richness of WZQ exhibits a greater number of outliers, indicating a higher degree of variability in vocabulary usage across his literary works.

Part-of-Speech (POS). The frequency of POS usage is a key indicator for measuring text style, and its variation can effectively reveal the distinctive features of different authors' linguistic styles. During the annotation process, certain POS subcategories were consolidated. Specifically, direction nouns (nd), personal names (nh), organization names (ni), location nouns (nl), geographical names (ns), temporal nouns (nt), and other proper nouns (nz) were grouped under the general noun category (n), while numbers (m) and quantities (q) were designated as a single category labeled numbers and quantities (mq). The top nine POS categories from each author's corpus were selected for statistical comparison.

These nine POS categories can be broadly divided into two types. The first type comprises

content words, which carry semantic meaning and serve as primary vehicles for conveying information, thus reflecting the informational density of a text. This group includes nouns, verbs, adjectives, numerals and quantities, and pronouns. The second type consists of function words, which do not contribute to the thematic content of the text but instead provide grammatical structure. This category includes adverbs (d), conjunctions (c), auxiliaries (u), and prepositions (p). This classification corresponds to the visual representations shown in Fig. 3a and Fig. 3b, respectively. Overall, the percentages of content words in WZQ (74.72%) are higher than those in SCW (72.31%), suggesting that the texts of WZQ contain more information.

The analysis using the t-test and Mann-Whitney U test reveals significant differences in the distribution of POS between the two authors, except for auxiliaries. Specifically, SCW uses more frequently than WZQ in terms of verbs ($t = -4.291$, $df = 154.982$, $p = 0.00$), prepositions ($t = -12.760$, $df = 175.188$, $p = 0.00$), Adverb ($t = -8.954$, $df = 135.963$, $p = 0.00$), conjunctions ($u = 7624.5$, $z = -6.372$, $p = 0.00$), and pronouns ($u = 6313.0$, $z = -7.703$, $p = 0.00$). In comparison, WZQ uses more frequently in nouns ($t = 9.468$, $df = 416$, $p = 0.00$), adjectives ($u = 11021.5$, $z = -2.924$, $p = 0.00$), numbers and quantities ($u = 7096.500$, $z = -6.907$, $p = 0.00$).

This section offers a close analysis of several key categories of content words. First, the proportion of verbs is higher in the writing of SCW (26.29%) compared to that of WZQ (25.47%), suggesting that the frequent use of verbs by SCW contributes to a more dynamic narrative and a quicker pace of plot development. This finding aligns with the discovery of his high Activity value. Second, WZQ demonstrates a higher overall proportion of nouns (see Fig. 3a), including directional nouns, proper names, and locative nouns. This suggests a greater focus on setting construction and environmental detail, reflecting WZQ's stylistic preference for establishing contextual richness and narrative atmosphere. Third, the use of mq is also more prominent in WZQ's work (8.29%) compared to SCW's (6.57%). These elements frequently co-occur with concrete nouns and serve to enhance descriptive precision. WZQ's reliance on specific quantities underscores his attentiveness to sensory detail, particularly in the depiction of objects, characters,

and scenes. For instance, in *Shou Ba Yangrou*, he employs expressions such as 大块 (a big chunk of), 一手 (handful), and 一碗 (a bowl of) to convey the distinctive preparation and consumption rituals of Chinese Mongolian cuisine. These descriptions not only reinforce the materiality of the narrative but also authentically represent cultural specificity. Fourth, WZQ exhibits a higher frequency of adjectives. Adjectives function to delineate the properties, states, and emotional tones of entities within a narrative. The high frequency of adjectives in WZQ's work underscores his stylistic orientation toward precision and affective richness, especially in descriptive passages involving characters and settings. Finally, pronoun usage is more frequent in SCW's writing (10.21%) than in WZQ's (7.18%) (see Fig. 3a). Pronouns, including demonstrative and personal forms, function anaphorically to reference previously introduced nouns. This usage pattern complements SCW's lower noun density, suggesting a cohesive strategy that emphasizes textual economy and referential continuity over repetitive nominal expression. The higher frequency of pronoun usage in SCW complements his lower noun density, a distribution pattern that aligns with the findings of Hudson (1994).

Having examined the distribution and stylistic functions of content words, this section proceeds to a detailed analysis of function words, which are widely recognized as linguistic markers of unconscious authorial tendencies and thus serve as critical indicators for profiling writing habits and stylistic patterns (Chung and Pennebaker, 2011). The percentage of function word usage in SCW (26.40%) is higher than that in WZQ (23.46%).

First, as illustrated in Figure 3b, SCW uses adverbs, prepositions, and conjunctions more frequently than WZQ, indicating a significant divergence in function word usage between the two authors. Adverbs are primarily used to modify verbs and other content words, and their usage frequency is positively correlated with that of verbs. The higher frequency of adverb usage in SCW aligns with the conclusion that he uses verbs more frequently. The data show that SCW employs prepositions at a significantly higher rate than WZQ, indicating a more literarily sophisticated and rhetorically elaborate style (Zeng and Zhu, 2006). In addition, the frequent use of conjunctions in

the writing of SCW suggests a stylistic preference for complex sentence structures, as conjunctions primarily serve to link clauses and phrases. This is consistent with the observation by Gao (2019) that SCW frequently uses parallel constructions, which typically involve multiple coordinated clauses or phrases. The internal cohesion of such structures often relies on conjunctions, which helps explain their elevated frequency in texts written by SCW. Previous research has also noted his distinctive lexical choice within this category. Yan and Su (2011) observed that SCW habitually replaces disyllabic conjunctions with their monosyllabic counterparts, giving the language a concise, classical charm and enhancing its defamiliarizing effect. For example, SCW tends to favor monosyllabic conjunctions over their disyllabic counterparts. To further investigate this preference, this study analyzes the frequency of the four sets of synonymous conjunctions identified by Yan and Su (2011), as shown in Table 3.

As shown in Table 3, SCW uses the disyllabic conjunction 所以 (therefore) with significantly greater frequency than its synonymous monosyllabic counterpart 故 (therefore), a finding that diverges from the results reported by Yan and Su (2011). This discrepancy may be attributed to divergences in corpus selection and analytical methodology between the present study and Yan and Su (2011). While their investigation was confined to a single excerpt from *Bian Cheng*, it lacked a comprehensive, large-scale quantitative analysis across SCW's broader oeuvre. However, when considering the overall frequency statistics of the four sets of synonymous conjunctions examined in this study, SCW still demonstrates a clear preference for monosyllabic forms, which are more characteristic of classical Chinese. Classical Chinese is marked by its linguistic economy, often conveying profound meanings with minimal lexical material, thereby achieving a rhetorical effect of brevity and depth. SCW draws upon this stylistic principle by integrating the concise features of classical function words into his vernacular prose, producing a seamless synthesis of classical elegance and modern grammatical structure. This distinctive usage not only contributes to SCW's refined and literarily sophisticated style but also generates a defamiliarization effect that enhances the aesthetic impact of his writing.

Distribution of Word Length. In Chinese, word length typically refers to the number of characters contained in a word. This study primarily analyzes the usage differences between the two authors in terms of 1-character words, 2-character words, 3-character words, and 4-character words in their literary texts, see Figure. 4.

The t-test and Mann-Whitney U test revealed significant differences in the usage of 1-character words ($t = 3.060$, $df = 416$, $p = 0.002$), 2-character words ($u = 6201.0$, $z = -7.816$, $p = 0.00$), 3-character words ($t = 12.378$, $df = 416$, $p = 0.000$), and 4-character words ($u = 5582.5$, $z = -8.444$, $p = 0.00$) between the two authors. As shown in Fig. 4, the percentage of 2-character words is higher in SCW (38.43%) than in WZQ (34.06%). However, the percentages of 1-character words, 3-character words, and 4-character words are significantly higher in WZQ than in SCW.

PCA results. The literary style characteristics of the two authors are analyzed through dimensionality reduction and visualization using PCA (see Fig.5). A total of 18 indicators were selected as input variables for the analysis, including Activity, Descriptivity, Nominality, Lexical Richness, Word Length Distribution, and Part-of-Speech Distribution. The first principal component (PC1) and the second principal component (PC2) jointly account for 42.2% of the total variance, with PC1 explaining 25.1% and PC2 explaining 17.1%. As illustrated in Fig. 5, the distributions of text samples for SCW (the yellow region) and WZQ (the blue region) reveal both areas of overlap and pronounced separation. The overlapping regions suggest shared linguistic features between the two authors, whereas the separate clusters indicate stylistic divergences that define each author's individual writing style.

The PC1 is primarily characterized by positive loadings in descriptivity, nominality, and the distribution of four-character and three-character words, while negative loadings include activity, pronoun usage rate, and the distribution of one-character words. In this dimension, the SCW samples are primarily concentrated on the left side of the axis, while the samples of WZQ are

distributed on both sides, with a higher concentration on the right. This suggests that the linguistic style of SCW is more inclined towards dynamic scene narration, whereas WZQ tends to favor static descriptive narration. The PC2 dimension primarily reflects variations in language formality and complexity, as well as differences in conciseness and the degree of colloquialism. In this dimension, the SCW samples are primarily concentrated above the axis, while the samples of WZQ are scattered on both the upper and lower sides, with a greater concentration at the bottom. The distributional differences in this dimension suggest that SCW tends to adopt a more complex and ornate literary style, whereas WZQ favors a simpler, more natural, and colloquial expression.

Discussion. The preceding results reveal both convergences and divergences in the linguistic styles of SCW and WZQ, with these quantitative measures providing an objective empirical basis for distinguishing their respective stylistic profiles. However, the formation of linguistic style is the product of a complex interplay among multiple factors. Li (2002) conceptualizes the determinants of linguistic style as comprising both subjective and objective factors. An author's stylistic choices are shaped not only by internal influences, including cognition, psychological dispositions, and value orientations, but also by external constraints, such as the social milieu and the broader historical-cultural context. Simpson and Hal (2002) note that literature represents instances of natural language use within specific social contexts. The analysis of literary language and texts cannot be conducted in isolation from an examination of the authors and the socio-cultural contexts in which their works were produced (Candria, 2019). Based on this, we conduct a comprehensive analysis of the factors underlying the stylistic differences between the two authors, examining their individual creative philosophies, the diachronic evolution of Modern Chinese, and the socio-historical contexts in which their works were produced.

The Evolution of Modern Chinese as an Explanation. First, differences in POS usage can be explained with reference to the characteristics of Modern Chinese corresponding to the authors' respective periods of writing. Previous studies have shown that features of Europeanized Modern

Chinese include increased use of pronouns, prepositions, conjunctions, and disyllabic words (He, 2008; Cordes, 2014). Therefore, the frequencies of these features serve as core features for assessing a text's Europeanization style, with their fluctuations directly reflecting the dynamic shifts of literary language between Europeanization and De-europeanization. The data show that SCW's usage frequencies of adverbs, conjunctions, and prepositions are all significantly higher than those of WZQ, indicating a Europeanized style in his literary language and corroborating Gunn's (1991) characterization of SCW's linguistic style. SCW's literary activity corresponds to the first stage of Modern Chinese development, a period during which the language was markedly influenced by foreign linguistic forms, particularly Indo-European languages and Japanese (Cui et al., 2022). Such influences may have partially contributed to the Europeanized tendencies observed in the literary style of this period. At this time, vocabulary still retained a substantial number of classical terms, which helps explain his preference for using classical Chinese conjunctions. Quantitative data indicate a significant decrease in WZQ's use of linguistic features associated with a Europeanized style, suggesting that he also sought to distance his style from "Europeanized" (Ouhua) or "translated-style" (fanyi ti) modes (FitzGerald, 2008). This transition is by no means accidental; rather, it is intricately linked to the historical stages of Modern Chinese development. In tracing the evolutionary trajectory of Modern Chinese, the second period serves as a critical bridge. This external context may, to some extent, account for WZQ's preference for more standardized and communicatively frequent disyllabic conjunctions, as well as the colloquialized style observed throughout his literary works.

Secondly, evolution in Modern Chinese and shifts in POS usage partially account for the distributional variations in word length. Zhang (2024) conducted a systematic study of Modern Chinese vocabulary, showing that nouns, adjectives, and verbs tend to be disyllabic, whereas exclamations, auxiliaries, and numeral-classifiers are predominantly monosyllabic. In the present study, numeral-classifiers account for 2.37% of SCW's texts and 3.42% of WZQ's. Statistical analysis (Fig. 3) further indicates that the proportion of disyllabic-leaning categories (nouns, verbs,

adjectives) in SCW's works is 55.53%, significantly higher than WZQ's 33.78%. Conversely, for monosyllabic-leaning categories (auxiliaries and quantities), WZQ exhibits higher usage (12.89%) than SCW (11.83%). These findings suggest that differences in POS distribution between the two authors may underlie their divergent patterns in the use of monosyllabic and disyllabic words. Furthermore, during the third period of Modern Chinese development, the average length of newly coined words increased relative to earlier periods, and the number of trisyllabic and longer words rose markedly (Liang, 2022). This macro-level trend is reflected in the literary works of the two authors, with WZQ generally using trisyllabic and tetrasyllabic words more frequently than SCW. These differences not only indicate individual variations in linguistic choices but also subtly highlight the broader trend toward lexical multisyllabicity characteristic of the third period of Modern Chinese.

Finally, word choice is closely related to an author's linguistic context. In expressing concepts such as "young age" and "affection," SCW preferred terms like 年青 and 欢喜, which retain archaic or transitional connotations, whereas WZQ more frequently used modern, widely accepted expressions such as 年轻 and 喜欢. This difference reflects the developmental stages of Modern Chinese, during SCW's creative period in the 1930s, the language was still in a formative and transitional phase, with Classical Chinese and older vernacular elements remaining. In contrast, WZQ's literary activity in the 1980s occurred after the extensive, state-led language standardization initiatives. Within this sociolinguistic context, expressions such as 年轻 and 喜欢 gradually supplanted older synonyms to become the more prevalent normative forms in contemporary communication. WZQ's frequent use of these standardized expressions in his works not only aligns with his late-career aesthetic of plain yet profound style, but also subtly evidences the potential shaping effect of the broader linguistic environment on individual authorial practices.

The socio-historical context as an explanation. The socio-historical context provides a crucial perspective for explaining the divergence in the stylistic tone of the two authors. In terms of adjective keyword usage, words such as 沉默 (silent) and 寂寞 (lonely) occur in SCW's texts,

reflecting an overarching melancholic emotional tone, whereas WZQ's works display a comparatively brighter and more optimistic tonal quality. Alexander (2004) argues that cultural trauma arises when individuals or groups perceive that they have undergone horrific events that leave indelible marks on collective consciousness, become permanent memories, and fundamentally and irreversibly reshape their future. SCW's stylistic orientation is deeply embedded in such a traumatic sensibility. First, SCW's works are permeated with an implicit sense of pain rooted in marginalized ethnic cultures. The long-term exclusion and misinterpretation of ethnic minority communities in Western Hunan by dominant ideological frameworks constitute a structural condition that gives rise to the melancholic undertone of his writing. Second, the coercive intrusion of war and the bureaucratic apparatus disrupted the established hegemonic order of indigenous culture in western Hunan. SCW clearly recognized that the idealized Xiangxi of his imagination had already been swept into the turbulent currents of warfare and poverty. Yet he continued to construct, through literary representation, a "textual coordinate" capable of resisting the crisis of modernity and of sustaining his utopian aspirations. Consequently, beneath the seemingly graceful and limpid prose lies an inescapable sense of helplessness attendant upon the collapse of an ideal world. Third, national turmoil and individual destiny. SCW experienced a dramatic shift from the privileged life of a well-to-do youth in western Hunan to familial decline, entering military service at an early age. In this formative period, he directly witnessed the atrocities committed by the old warlord regimes, as well as the misfortune and suffering endured by the people of western Hunan (Tai, 2003). The transformation of his personal identity intersected with the large-scale upheavals of a nation beset by internal strife and external threats, and this convergence inevitably infused his narrative with an inescapable tragic sensibility. By contrast, WZQ's writing was profoundly shaped by the intellectual liberation of the 1980s. Reflecting on several of his works from the early 1980s, Wang candidly acknowledged that his creative practice was clearly influenced, albeit indirectly, by the Third Plenum of the Eleventh Central Committee. With the convening of the Third Plenum, minds across the nation were emancipated and public

sentiment became animated; consequently, the overall tone of some of my works (such as *Shoujie* and *Danao jishi*) is notably light and buoyant (Wang, 2018). This observation suggests that the brightness and warmth characteristic of WZQ's writing are closely tied to the hopeful social atmosphere of the historical period in which he was writing.

From the perspective of dynamic versus static narrative, SCW's texts exhibit higher levels of activity, reflecting a tendency to construct narratives centered on plot development, whereas WZQ's texts display greater descriptiveness, indicating a preference for static narrative focused on scenes and detail. This stylistic divergence is partly associated with the distinct socio-historical contexts in which each author operated. The historical period in which SCW lived, together with his personal circumstances, was characterized by multiple tensions and conflicts. Such conflicts are difficult to convey adequately through static description and therefore inclined him toward a dynamic narrative mode in which narrative structure is centered on action, change, and event-driven development. His writing emerged in an era marked by recurrent national crises, during which literature was widely invested with the functions of enlightenment and national salvation. In this context, he adhered to modernist aesthetic experimentation. This literary orientation, which did not occupy a dominant position amid the escalating national crisis (Kinkley, 2006), created a sharp confrontation with the prevailing mainstream literary values, a tension that in turn infused his writing with a pronounced sense of dynamism. At the same time, the text exhibits a profound nostalgia for the vanishing age of innocence (Wang, 1993). The collision between reality and imagination further heightens the instability within the narrative, which ultimately manifests at the structural level as a dynamic narrative characterized by fluidity, mobility, and event-driven development. For example SCW's narrative dynamism peaks in the open-ended conclusion of *biancheng*. By leaving the character's return suspended between never and tomorrow, he preserves narrative momentum and reflects the unsettled socio-historical conditions of his era, thereby producing a distinctive dynamic narrative. By contrast, WZQ's literary reemergence in the 1980s coincided with a period of cultural reconstruction and intellectual liberalization in China. His

creative focus shifted from the previously tumultuous themes of class struggle to a renewed exploration of cultural roots. In order to restore fragmented cultural memory and mitigate the tensions inherent in grand political narratives, Wang redirected the narrative emphasis from turbulent plot progression to depictions of local landscapes and folk customs (FitzGerald, 2008), resulting in a narrative structure centered on scene construction and detailed description, characteristic of a predominantly static mode of storytelling.

Personal creative philosophy as an Explanation. First, personal creative philosophy also significantly influences an author's narrative methodology. The disparity between activity and descriptivity indicates that while SCW prioritizes the progression of dynamic narratives, WZQ focuses on static and evocative scene-building. Quantitative results show a higher frequency of verbs and pronouns in SCW's works, reflecting his emphasis on the character's activity. As Han (1991) notes, SCW tends to reveal abstract psychological states through characters' specific actions and speech, which are the external manifestations of mental activity, while simultaneously presenting the paradoxical unity of social consciousness, life consciousness, and philosophical awareness. For example, in the short story *San San*:

三三轻轻地呸了一口，停顿了一下，把两个指头紧紧地塞了耳朵，但依然听到两人的笑声，
她想知道那个城里来的好像唱小生的人还要说些什么，所以不久就继续跟上前去。

San San lightly spat, paused for a moment, and pressed her two fingers tightly into her ears, yet she could still hear the laughter of the two. She wondered what the young man from the city, who seemed to sing in the style of a young scholar, would say next, and before long, she continued to follow him forward.

SCW vividly portrays the intricate emotional responses of an adolescent girl, who

simultaneously experiences repulsion and desire, as well as shyness and curiosity, upon hearing a joke about a marriage proposal. These conflicting emotions are embodied in her physical responses, including 呖 (bah), 停顿 (pause), and 跟上前去 (catch up with and go forward), all of which dramatize her inner conflict and emerging emotional complexity. This strategy of depicting psychological states through physical actions drives the progression of the plot and endows the text with dynamic narrative progression.

In contrast, WZQ was less interested in depicting the harsh realities that modernization brought to rural areas. He focused on the etymological workings of local language, viewing it as a cornerstone for constructing indigenous culture. His aim was to explore past regional cultures and traditions embedded within modern Chinese. For example, in the short story *Shoujie*:

英子跳到中舱，两只桨飞快地划起来，划进了芦花荡。芦花才吐新穗。紫灰色的芦穗，发着银光，软软的，滑溜溜的，像一串丝线。有的地方结了蒲棒，通红的，像一枝一枝小蜡烛。青浮萍，紫浮萍。长脚蚊子，水蜘蛛。野菱角开着四瓣的小白花。惊起一只青桩（一种水鸟），擦着芦穗，扑鲁鲁鲁飞远了。

Yingzi jumped into the middle cabin, and the two oars flew through the water as she rowed swiftly into the reed marsh. The reeds had just sprouted new plumes. The purplish-gray reed tips shimmered like silver, soft and slippery, like strands of silk. In some places, the cattails had matured, bright red, resembling tiny candles clustered together. Green duckweed, purple duckweed. Long-legged mosquitoes, water spiders. Wild water caltrops bloomed with four-petaled little white flowers. A green bittern, startled, brushed against the reeds and flapped away with a ruffling sound.

Wang Zengqi does not depict intense psychological conflicts or dramatic actions; instead, he directs the reader's attention to objects such as "reeds," "sunlight," and "duckweed." This

approach significantly slows the narrative pace, creating a sense of static beauty. FitzGerald (2008) also notes that the flow of the “plot” is not central in *Shoujie*. At the core of WZQ’s writing is a “poetic depiction” constructed from memory. The narrative’s momentum no longer derives from the characters’ actions, but from the depiction of the environment.

Secondly, the emotional tone can also be explained in terms of the author’s creative philosophy. WZQ’s works examined in this study were written in the 1980s. Reflecting on his creative approach, WZQ (2018) remarked, “Who has ever decreed that life before liberation cannot be represented? ... Was there really no joy in the old society, that we cannot offer something to people today?” In the same year, he completed *Shoujie*. This pursuit of the joys of everyday life imbues his post-1980 works with a generally bright and optimistic tone, which is corroborated by the prevalence of adjectives such as “好吃 delicious,” “好看 beautiful,” and “舒服 comfortable” in the present study.

Finally, drawing on the boxplots (Figures 1 and 2) and the PCA results, WZQ’s data points are more widely dispersed, indicating a higher degree of stylistic flexibility in his writing, characterized by an interplay between classical and vernacular elements. In contrast, SCW’s texts exhibit greater stylistic stability. This difference can be further interpreted in light of the authors’ linguistic conceptions and literary orientations. During his time at the Southwest Associated University, SCW primarily taught the writing of stylistic prose, and some of his works bear clear exemplary features (Li, 2005). WZQ’s literary thought matured under the intellectual enlightenment he received during the same period. As WZQ himself recalled, “If I had not attended the Southwest Associated University, I might not have become a writer, or at least not a writer like I am today” (Wang, 1998). The vernacular-classical hybridity in WZQ’s writing does not reflect wavering aesthetic preferences, but rather represents a continuation of the integration theory¹ he practiced during his university years. He studied a wide range of courses on new literature and advocated the aesthetic compatibility of Chinese and Western literature, as well as classical, modern, and folk traditions. This stylistic formation is rooted in his unique view of language as

ontological. As Li (1998) points out, WZQ not only sought linguistic resources from folk and everyday speech, but also attached great importance to drawing nourishment from classical Chinese writing. His various linguistic experiments were deliberate. Root-seeking writers, with Wang as a representative, aspired to create a new literary language that was distinctly their own while retaining refined aesthetic qualities. This stylistic approach thus reflects a personal choice grounded in a particular philosophy of language.

Conclusion. This study employs a range of lexical quantitative indicators, including keywords, activity, nominality, descriptivity, lexical richness, word length distribution, and POS patterns, to investigate the stylistic similarities and differences in the literary language of SCW and WZQ, a master-disciple pair in the Beijing school of modern Chinese literature. The analysis reveals that while their linguistic styles reflect a clear lineage of stylistic inheritance, they also demonstrate distinct individual characteristics in literary expression.

In terms of stylistic inheritance, SCW and WZQ, as representative authors of the Beijing School, continue the tradition of celebrating pure human nature and sincere human emotions in their literary themes. Through nuanced depictions of ordinary daily life, rural memory, and the inner world of intellectuals, both authors exemplify the Beijing School's characteristic humanistic ethos and aesthetic aspirations. Second, their stylistic profiles exhibit notable convergence across the dimensions of Activity, Nominality, and Descriptivity, manifested in high Activity scores, moderate Nominality, and relatively low Descriptivity. These shared stylistic features reflect a common tendency toward dynamic narrative progression, economical language use, and a selective integration of descriptive elements focused on setting and character portrayal. Moreover, both authors demonstrate a high level of lexical sophistication, as indicated by mean MATTR values exceeding 0.7, which reflects their literary competence. Their pursuit of defamiliarization through deviation from conventional linguistic patterns further contributes to a novel and engaging reading experience. Finally, both SCW and WZQ inherit the classical aesthetic orientation of the Beijing School. Their writing consistently incorporates Chinese traditional literary techniques,

endowing their texts with a distinctive classical aesthetic and stylistic elegance.

Despite their shared literary lineage, differences in personal creative philosophy, the socio-historical development of Modern Chinese, and their respective historical contexts led each author to develop a highly distinctive linguistic style in their writing. First, there are distinct differences in the focus of character portrayal. SCW primarily concentrates on women and youth, with an emphasis on the psychological and spiritual dimensions of the characters. In contrast, WZQ tends to center his narratives on ordinary people, engaging with a broader thematic spectrum and offering a more diversified portrayal of mundane life. Second, regarding the emotional tone of their works, SCW's writing often reveals a somewhat austere and melancholy sense of tragedy, whereas WZQ's works present a warmer and more luminous aesthetic style.

Finally, in terms of narrative tone, SCW emphasizes constructing a dynamic narrative rhythm, using rigorous and complex linguistic structures that often bear traces of early European-influenced Modern Chinese to drive plot development. In contrast, WZQ favors static scene depiction, frequently employing adjectives and quantities to highlight detailed portrayals, thereby forming a distinctive hybrid vernacular–classical linguistic style.

Whereas previous studies primarily relied on introspective methods to compare the linguistic styles of SCW and WZQ, the present study approaches the comparison from the perspective of their master-disciple relationship. By combining distant reading with close reading, it examines both the commonalities and differences in their literary works and provides a quantitative foundation for the comparative analysis of stylistic variation across generations of authors. It is important to recognize that stylistic features are multidimensional. In future research, a richer set of lexical indicators could be selected, such as expanding the part-of-speech coverage of keywords, while also incorporating syntactic and semantic metrics into a comprehensive analysis to more fully characterize the stylistic differences between the two authors. Moreover, this study primarily focuses on the Master-disciple lineage within the Beijing School. Future studies could broaden the scope to include multiple authors within the same literary school and conduct systematic cross-

school comparisons. By introducing more representative author groups, such as the Shanghai School, the Leftist writers, and the Modernists, it would be possible to construct a multidimensional coordinate system of stylistic features in modern Chinese literature.

Notes

1. Wang Zengqi expressed skepticism regarding the popular saying “the more national it is, the more international it becomes,” arguing it lacked logical consistency. Instead, he highly advocated Qian Zhongshu’s “integration theory” (or *datong shuo*), which he interpreted as the breaking of boundaries between Chinese and Western literatures. Wang maintained that contemporary Chinese literature should seek a seamless integration with Western traditions rather than establishing barriers (Wang, 1998).

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Figure.1 Boxplot of Activity, Descriptivity, Nominality values in SCW and WZQ corpora. Figures 1(a), 1(b), and 1(c) respectively present the Activity, Descriptivity, and Nominality values observed in the SCW and WZQ corpora (SCW works = 83; WZQ works = 335).

Figure.2 Boxplot of MATTR_mean values in SCW and WZQ corpora (SCW works = 83; WZQ works = 335).

Figure 3. Distribution of Content Words and Function Words in SCW and WZQ corpora. Figure 3(a) illustrates the proportions of content words, including nouns (n), verbs (v), adjectives (a), measure–quantifiers (mq), and pronouns (r) in the SCW and WZQ corpora, while Figure 3(b) presents the proportions of function words including adverbs (d), conjunctions (c), auxiliaries (u), and prepositions (p) — in the same corpora (SCW works =83, WZQ works = 335).

Figure 4. Distribution of Word Length in SCW and WZQ corpora (SCW works =83, WZQ works = 335).

Figure 5. The results of PCA. Figure 5 presents a visualization of the textual style analysis of the two authors (SCW works =83, WZQ works = 335) .

Table 1. Basic Information of the Corpus

Author	Works Number	Token Number
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SCW	83	583,055
WZQ	335	556,743
Total	418	1,139,798

Table2. Keywords in the corpora of SCW and WZQ

POS	SCW	WZQ
noun	女人 (nǚrén, woman)	先生 (xiānsheng, Mr.)
	男子 (nánzǐ, man)	昆明 (Kūnmíng, Kunming)
	女子 (nǚzǐ, girl)	北京 (Běijīng, Beijing)
	妇人 (fūrén, married woman)	学生 (xuésheng, student)
	事情 (shìqíng, thing)	现在 (xiànzài, now)
	地方 (dìfang, place)	中国 (Zhōngguó, China)
	朋友 (péngyou, friend)	父亲 (fùqīn, father)
	国王 (guówáng, king)	同学 (tóngxué, classmate)
	先生 (xiānsheng, Mr.)	地方 (dìfang, place)
	年青人 (niánqīngrén, youth)	后来 (hòulái, later on)
	声音 (shēngyīn, sound)	孩子 (háizi, child)
	东西 (dōngxi, thing)	小说 (xiǎoshuō, novel)
	情形 (qíngxíng, situation)	联大 (Liándà, Associated University)
	故事 (gùshi, story)	和尚 (héshang, monk)
	兵士 (bīngshì, soldier)	同志 (tóngzhì, comrade)
	时节 (shíjié, season)	作家 (zuòjiā, writer)
	医生 (yīshēng, doctor)	美国 (Měiguó, America)
	样子 (xiàngzi, personal names)	演员 (yǎnyuán, actor/actress)
	太太 (tàitai, wife)	茶馆 (cháguǎn, teahouse)
	阿黑 (Āhēi, personal name)	裘盛戎 (Qiú Shèngrōng, personal name)
	应当 (yīngdāng, should)	没有 (méiyǒu, don't have)

Verb	听到 (tīngdào, hear)	有 (yǒu, have)
	以为 (yǐwéi, think)	知道 (zhīdào, know)
	见到 (jiàndào, see)	觉得 (juéde, feel)
	没有 (méiyǒu, don't have)	不知 (bùzhī, don't know)
	得到 (dédao, get)	以为 (yǐwéi, think)
	欢喜 (huānxǐ, like)	看到 (kàndào, see)
	好象 (hǎoxiàng, as if)	记得 (jìde, remember)
	说话 (shuōhuà, speak)	起来 (qǐlái, rise up)
	觉得 (juéde, think)	出来 (chūlái, come out)
	看到 (kàndào, see)	下来 (xiàlái, come down)
	看看 (kànkàn, take a look)	回来 (huílái, come back)
	愿意 (yuànyì, willing)	叫做 (jiàozuò, be called)
	下去 (xiàqù, go down)	看见 (kànjiàn, see)
	预备 (yùbèi, prepare)	看看 (kànkàn, take a look)
	微笑 (wēixiào, smile)	比较 (bǐjiào, compare)
	想到 (xiǎngdào, realize)	喜欢 (xǐhuan, like)
	发生 (fāshēng, happen)	据说 (jùshuō, it is said)
	注意 (zhùyì, notice)	研究 (yánjiū, study)
	缺少 (quēshǎo, lack)	希望 (xīwàng, hope)
	明白 (míngbai, clear)	好吃 (hǎochī, delicious)
	完全 (wánquán, entirely)	好看 (hǎokàn, beautiful)
	神气 (shénqì, spirited)	实在 (shízài, reliable)
	年青 (niánqīng, young)	不错 (bùcuò, pretty good)
	快乐 (kuàilè, happy)	不好 (bùhǎo, bad)
	美丽 (měilì, beautiful)	大 (dà, big)
	沉默 (chénmò, silent)	年轻 (niánqīng, young)

	方便 (fāngbiàn, convenient)	清楚 (qīngchu, clear)
	容易 (róngyì, easy)	干净 (gānjìng, clean)
adjective	幸福 (xìngfú, happy)	臭 (chòu, smelly)
	体面 (tǐmiàn, decent)	不同 (bùtóng, different)
	不行 (bùxíng, unacceptable)	简单 (jiǎndān, simple)
	高兴 (gāoxìng, happy)	平常 (píngcháng, ordinary)
	实在 (shízài, indeed)	舒服 (shūfu, comfortable)
	寂寞 (jìmò, lonely)	新鲜 (xīnxiān, fresh)
	不同 (bùtóng, different)	完全 (wánquán, complete)
	大 (dà, big)	有名 (yǒumíng, famous)
	聪明 (cōngmíng, smart)	便宜 (piányi, cheap)
	小心 (xiǎoxīn, careful)	难得 (nándé, rarely)
	怪 (guài, strange)	高大 (gāodà, tall)

Table 3. Usage Frequencies of Synonymous Conjunctions in the SCW Corpus

1-Chinese-character words	Usage frequency	2-Chinese-character words	Usage frequency
若 (ruò, if)	500	如果 (rúguǒ, if)	35
故 (gù, therefore)	266	所以 (suǒyǐ, therefore)	642
且 (qiě, and)	726	而且 (érqiě, and)	102
或 (huò, or)	463	或者 (huòzhě, or)	297
Total	1955	Total	1076

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Ethical Approval

This article does not contain any studies with human participants performed by any of the authors.

Informed Consent

This article does not contain any studies with human participants performed by any of the authors.





